Charles Masson, another survivor from pre-war Kabul, also came to a sad end. After the failure of the 1837–8 Burnes mission, he found himself sidelined by the Company as it prepared for war with Afghanistan, even though he knew the country much more intimately than any other Englishman. Later, while attempting to make his way back to Kabul in 1840, walking along the British line of march through country which he said had been devastated by the passage of the Army of the Indus, he had got as far as Qalat when the British stormed the city. On its capture Masson found himself arrested and imprisoned as a traitor and a spy. It took him over six months to prove his innocence and gain his release. When Henry Rawlinson later ran him to ground in Karachi, he was horrified by what had happened to the man he had long revered as the greatest archaeologist in the region: 'Whilst at Kurrachee Camp I rode into the town to see Masson of whom I have heard and read so much,' he wrote in his diary.

> I found him in a wretched hovel talking with some Belochees nearly naked and half drunk. I remained with him several hours and was extremely pained with all I witnessed. His language was at first so insolent that I thought he had become quite foolish. But at last he told me, having sat up writing he had dined of a bottle of wine and had risen at daylight with the fumes still in his head. I almost think however that his mind is really giving way – he gave me several papers to read which were written in the same vague and dreary style as he spoke in and all his information appeared to me to be lost by his method in putting it together. He is most bitter against Burnes and Wade and Lord Auckland . . . He has already written two volumes relating to his travels and his work in Afghanistan and was busy with his third – many parts of this which he showed me are very curious, but they will not stand publication – there is a sort of stilting in his language and vague fanciful fleeting in his ideas that the taste of the age will never tolerate. If Pottinger allows the MSS to be printed as it now is Masson will pass for a presumptuous ignoramus instead of the conscientious, hard working fellow he really is. I trust something will be done to get him to Bombay.[127]

But nothing was done, and Masson was forced to sit and watch as Macnaghten blundered fatally around Afghanistan, unable to do more than write anonymous embittered letters to the press. 'In your paper today,' reads one of his submissions, 'I observe that jackasses are to be employed in Afghanistan. What can be the reason for such a step? Are the camels of the country exhausted? Seeing that jackasses have been for a long time employed in the Political Department, is it the commencement of a system to introduce them to the military one, with a view to establishing uniformity in the services?'[128] He eventually made his way back to England where his publications received the derisory reviews Rawlinson had predicted, and